

January

25

1995

Missile scare

Mistaking Norwegian research rocket Black Brant XII for a US Trident missile, Russia prepared to launch a nuclear attack in retaliation. Thankfully, action was halted and procedures were reviewed to avoid similar incidents in the future.

Born this day

1759 Robert Burns, Scotland's national poet. He wrote about 300 poems, including *Auld Lang Syne*. His birthday is celebrated every year as Burns Night.

2004

Life on Mars

NASA's space rover *Opportunity* landed on Mars, where it spent 14 years gathering information. The most exciting revelation of its mission was historical evidence of water, making it possible that life may once have existed on Mars.

1921

Robot world

The word "robot" was heard for the first time in *Rossumovi Univerzální Roboti*, a science-fiction play by Czech writer Karel Čapek, which featured a robotic humanoid. This originated from the Czech word *robota*, meaning "forced labour".

Also on this day

1890 Nellie Bly, a US journalist, completed a trip around the world in a record-breaking 72 days.

1971 General Idi Amin seized power in Uganda. His eight-year rule was one of the most brutal leaderships in history.

2011 Protests against corruption and oppression erupted in Egypt as part of the Arab Spring, a series of uprisings that spread across many Arab countries.

